Give the first designer authority that matches the job

A founder worksheet for scope, ownership and the first real problem.

01	Choose the immediate mandate.	02	Set the mandate for the current stage.
03	Write the decision rights.	04	Agree the working relationship.
05	Describe the first problem honestly.	06	Check the role before writing the advertisement.

Choose the immediate mandate.

A first designer can cover several disciplines. The mandate still needs a priority when those disciplines compete for time.

MANDATE A

Make the core task usable

Spend early time on product decisions, research access and shipping with engineering.

MANDATE B

Establish the market-facing direction

Spend early time on positioning, identity and the product moments that must support the claim.

Set the mandate for the current stage.

Write the immediate priority and what should wait when responsibilities compete.

Immediate mandate

Which kind of decision needs the most help now?

Secondary responsibilities

What else is expected, and at what priority?

Work deliberately deferred

What should the designer not be judged on yet?

Write the decision rights.

Being responsible for the experience means little when every decision can be reopened without a clear owner.

Decision	Designer role	Other owner
Task flow and interaction	Recommend and resolve within agreed constraints.	Product and engineering clarify scope.
Positioning claim	Shape and challenge with customer evidence.	Founder owns the market choice.
Release priority	Explain the customer cost of each option.	Product owner sets the trade-off.

Agree the working relationship.

A title does not explain how the founder, product lead, engineer and designer will make decisions together.

Daily partners

Who brings product context and engineering constraints?

Escalation

Who resolves a disagreement the working team cannot settle?

Customer contact

How will the designer hear from the people using the product?

Describe the first problem honestly.

Give candidates the current task, the evidence you have and the access they will get. Avoid a disguised request to fix everything.

Current problem

Which customer decision or business claim is unclear?

Available evidence and access

What can they inspect? Who can they speak to?

First decision to make

Which choice should their work help the team make?

Check the role before writing the advertisement.

If the designer owns a result but cannot reach customers or influence priorities, the role needs another discussion.

Responsibility and authority

Which outcomes are expected? Which decisions can they affect?

Support and constraints

Who is the working partner? What cannot change?

Evidence of a useful start

What should be clearer after the first problem is investigated?